There was / there were

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

Qué vas a aprender

- Describe places in the past with there was and there were
- Choose was (singular) or were (plural)
- Make negatives and questions: there wasn't, Was there...?
- Compare a place in the past and now

Para pensar

En español decimos «había un castillo» y «había muchos caballos», siempre con «había». En inglés, ¿se dice igual para uno que para muchos?

Explicación

From there is to there was

You already know **there is** and **there are** (hay): «There **is** a park near my house», «There **are** two cinemas in my town». To talk about the **past** we use there was and there were (había, hubo).

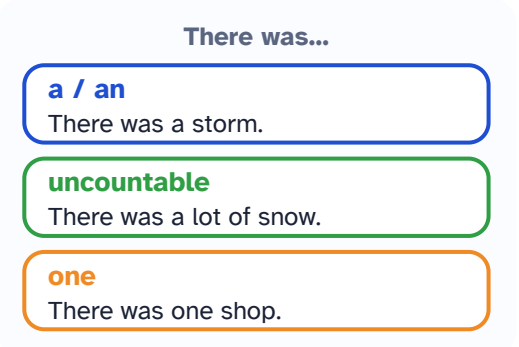
En castellano: «hay» pasa a ser «había». En inglés, el singular pasa a *was* y el plural a *were*, igual que el verbo *to be*: is → was, are → were.

Present	Past
There is a park.	There was a park.
There are trees.	There were trees.

There was: singular

Use there was with **one** thing (a / an / one) and with **uncountable** nouns (nombres incontables: water, food, snow, money): «There **was a** big storm last night», «There **was an** old tree in the square», «There **was** a lot of snow in the mountains».

The short form **there's** is only for the present. In the past we always write **there was** in full. **En castellano:** «había una tormenta», «había mucha nieve».



There were: plural

Use there were with **two or more** things: «There **were** twenty children in the classroom», «There **were some** beautiful shells on the beach», «There **were lots of** people at the concert».

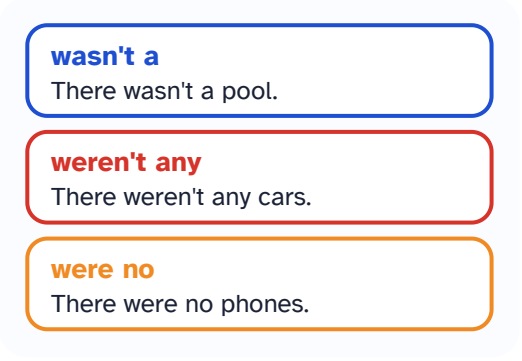
Careful with the first noun in a list: «There **was** a table and two chairs» (the first noun is singular) but «There **were** two chairs and a table». **En castellano:** mira la palabra que va justo detrás para elegir *was* o *were*.



Negatives: there wasn't, there weren't

Negative: there wasn't (was not) and there weren't (were not). With plural and uncountable nouns we usually add **any**: «There **wasn't a** swimming pool», «There **weren't any** cars in 1800», «There **wasn't any** milk in the fridge».

We can also say **there was no** / **there were no**: «There **were no** mobile phones when my grandma was a child». **En castellano:** «no había móviles». Ojo: nunca uses dos negaciones juntas («weren't no»).

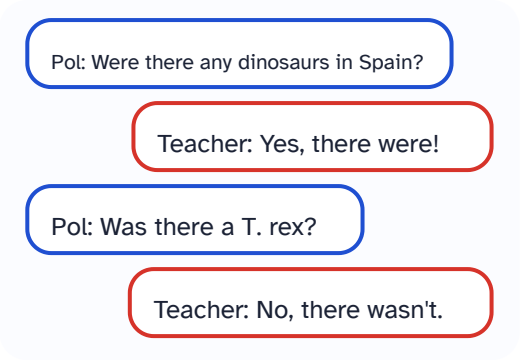


Questions and short answers

For questions we change the order: Was there...? and Were there...? «**Was there** a library in your school?» – «Yes, there was. / No, there wasn't». «**Were there any**

dinosaurs in Spain?» – «Yes, there were!».

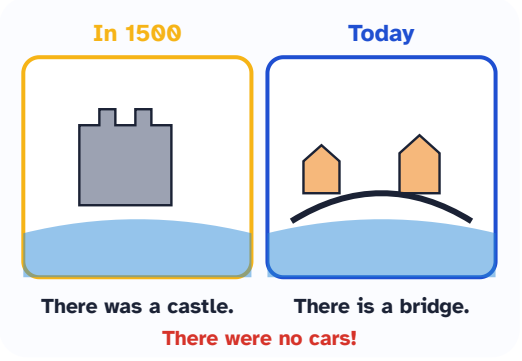
To ask about quantity: «**How many** people **were there**?» (countable) and «**How much** food **was there**?» (uncountable). **En castellano:** «¿Cuántas personas había?», «¿Cuánta comida había?».



My town in the past

We use there was / there were to **describe places** long ago: «A hundred years ago there **weren't** any supermarkets in my town. There **was** a small market in the square. There **were** lots of farms and there **was** a railway station. There **wasn't** any electricity in some houses».

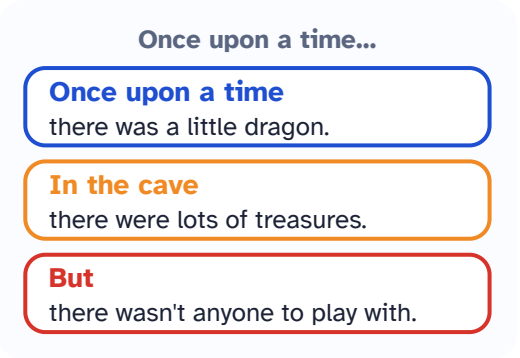
Compare with today using there is / there are: «Now there **is** a big supermarket and there **are** two schools». **Consejo:** pregunta a tus abuelos cómo era su pueblo y escríbelo en inglés.



Telling a story

Stories often start with there was or there were to present the place and the characters: «Once upon a time **there was** a little dragon who lived in a cave. **There were** lots of treasures in the cave, but **there wasn't** anyone to play with».

We use it to describe a scene: «When we arrived at the party, **there was** music and **there were** balloons everywhere». **En castellano:** «Érase una vez un dragón...» se dice en inglés «Once upon a time there was a dragon...».



Reading: a school trip to a castle

Read Nerea's text: «Last Friday we visited a castle. It was very old. Many years ago, **there were** soldiers and horses there. **There was** a big kitchen with a huge fireplace, but **there wasn't** a bathroom! **There were** some secret tunnels under the castle. «**Were there** any ghosts?» asked Mario. «No, **there weren't**», said the guide. «But **there was** a very old cat!». We all laughed.»

How many times do you see *there was*? And *there were*?



Let's practise: memory game

Look at a picture of a room for one minute. Then close your eyes. Your partner asks: «**Was there** a lamp?», «**How many** books **were there**?». Answer: «Yes, there was», «There were three books». Who remembers more?

Then describe a place you visited: «In the zoo **there were** lions and **there was** a big aquarium». **Consejo:** antes de escribir *was* o *were*, mira si lo que viene detrás

es uno, varios o incontable.

Question	Answer
Was there a lamp?	Yes, there was.
Were there any cats?	No, there weren't.
How many books?	There were three.

There was / there were

singular

THERE WAS

a castle
some snow

plural

THERE WERE

two towers
lots of people

negative

WASN'T / WEREN'T

any cars
a bathroom

question

WAS THERE...?

Yes, there was.
No, there weren't.

Ejercicios

1. **Complete: «There ___ a big storm yesterday.»**

2. **Complete: «There ___ ten pencils in my bag.»**

3. **Complete: «There ___ much water in the river.» (negative)**

4. **Make it negative: «There were some biscuits.»**

5. **Make a question: «There was a museum in your town.»**

6. **Short answer: «Were there any people?» (no)**

7. **Ask with How many: «There were five boats.»**

8. **Correct: «In 1900 it had no computers.»**

9. **Translate: «Había un perro y dos gatos.»**

10. **Write three sentences about your classroom in 1° of Primary.**

Practica

1. **«There ___ a cat on the roof.»**
   - **A)** were
   - **B)** was
   - **C)** had
2. **«There ___ two cats on the roof.»**
   - **A)** was
   - **B)** is
   - **C)** were
3. **«There ___ any milk.»**
   - **A)** wasn't
   - **B)** weren't
   - **C)** isn't no
4. **«___ there a park in your town?»**
   - **A)** Were
   - **B)** Did
   - **C)** Was
5. **«Were there any shops?» – «No, ___.»**
   - **A)** there wasn't
   - **B)** there weren't
   - **C)** they weren't
6. **«How many children ___?»**
   - **A)** were there
   - **B)** there were
   - **C)** was there
7. **«Había» in English is...**
   - **A)** it had
   - **B)** there was / there were
   - **C)** there has
8. **«There ___ a lot of snow last winter.»**
   - **A)** were

B) are

C) was

9. **«There were ___ phones in 1850.»**

A) no

B) not

C) any no

10. **Present of «there were» is...**

A) there is

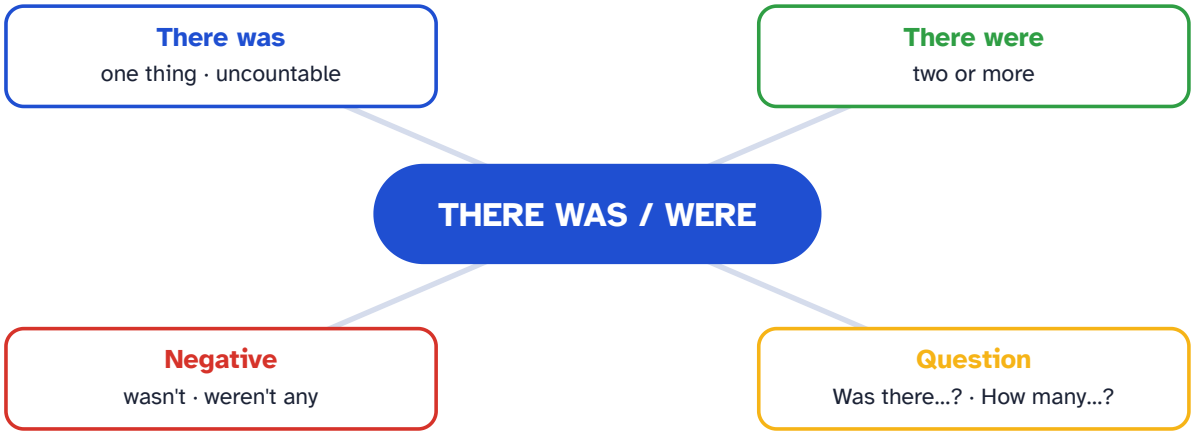
B) there are

C) there have

Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué significan there was y there were; Cuándo se usa was y cuándo were; Cómo se hacen las negativas con any y no; Cómo se pregunta y se contesta con respuestas cortas.

Resumen



Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

there was

Había (una cosa o incontable).

there were

Había (varias cosas).

there wasn't

No había (singular).

there weren't any

No había ningunos.

Was there...?

¿Había...? (singular).

Were there...?

¿Había...? (plural).

How many ... were there?

¿Cuántos ... había?

Once upon a time there was...

Érase una vez...

Soluciones

1. **B)** Una cosa: was.
2. **C)** Plural: were.
3. **A)** Incontable, negativa.
4. **C)** Singular: Was there...?
5. **B)** Respuesta corta.
6. **A)** Orden de pregunta, plural.
7. **B)** No se usa had.
8. **C)** Snow es incontable.
9. **A)** were no = no había.
10. **B)** were → are.

Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. was.
2. were.
3. wasn't.
4. There weren't any biscuits.
5. Was there a museum in your town?
6. No, there weren't.
7. How many boats were there?
8. In 1900 there were no computers.
9. There was a dog and two cats.
10. Model answer: There were lots of toys. There was a big carpet. There weren't any computers.